

The background is a deep blue gradient with a subtle pattern of white dots. On the left side, there are several concentric circles and a large circular scale with degree markings from 140 to 260. Some of the circles have arrows indicating a clockwise direction.

TONI MORRISON LIFE AND STRUGGLE

BY SHEEMA KHAN

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SUBJECT AMERICAN LITERATURE

SUBMITTED TO DR GULZAR JALAL



Original name: Chloe Ardelia Wofford

Born: February 18, 1931, Lorain, Ohio, U.S.

Died: August 5, 2019, Bronx, New York (aged 88)

Awards And Honors: Presidential Medal of Freedom (2012)

Nobel Prize (1993) Pulitzer Prize (1988)

Notable Works: "The Book About Mean People" "A Mercy"
"Beloved" "God Help the Child" "Home" "Jazz" "Love"

"Paradise" "Playing in the Dark: Whiteness and the Literary
Imagination" "Please, Louise" "Song of Solomon" "Sula"

"The Bluest Eye" "The Source of Self-Regard: Selected
Essays, Speeches, and Meditations" "What Moves at the
Margin: Selected Nonfiction"

Movement / Style: Black Arts movement.

TONI MORRISON

- Toni Morrison (born February 18, 1931, Lorain, Ohio, U.S.—died August 5, 2019, Bronx, New York) was an American writer noted for her examination of Black experience (particularly Black female experience) within the Black community and for her poetic, luminous prose. Considered one of the greatest contemporary American novelists, she received the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1993, becoming the first Black female writer in history to be honored with the prize.

EARLY LIFE AND EDUCATION

- Wofford grew up in the Midwest in a family that possessed an intense love of and appreciation for Black culture. Storytelling, songs, and folktales were a deeply formative part of her childhood. When Wofford was 12 years old she converted to Roman Catholicism and took “Anthony” as her baptismal name in honor of St. Anthony of Padua. After graduating from high school, she attended Howard University in Washington, D.C., where she began going by the nickname “Toni.” She graduated from Howard in 1953 with a bachelor’s degree in English and then began her graduate studies at Cornell University, receiving her master’s degree in 1955. After teaching at Texas Southern University for two years, she taught at Howard from 1957 to 1964. In 1958 she married Harold Morrison, a Jamaican architect. They were married six years before divorcing and had two sons together.

THE BLUEST EYE

- Morrison began writing fiction during her editing and teaching career. Eventually, she began crafting one of her early short stories, about a Black girl who longs to have blue eyes, into a longer work. That story became Morrison's first book, *The Bluest Eye* (1970), a novel of initiation concerning a victimized adolescent Black girl who is obsessed by white standards of beauty. The New York Times praised the book for "a prose so precise, so faithful to speech and so charged with pain and wonder that the novel becomes poetry."

SULA, SONG OF SOLOMON AND TAR BABY

- In 1973 Morrison published her second novel, *Sula*, which examines (among other issues) the dynamics of female friendship and the expectations for conformity within the Black community. In 1975 it was a finalist for a National Book Award. Her next novel, *Song of Solomon* (1977), featured a male narrator in search of his identity and incorporated elements of magical realism; its publication brought Morrison to national attention, and it won that year's National Book Critics Circle Award. It was followed by *Tar Baby* (1981), which is set on a Caribbean island and explores conflicts of race, class, and gender.

BELOVED

- In 1987 Morrison published the critically acclaimed *Beloved*, which won a Pulitzer Prize for fiction. Set in the 19th century and based on a true story, the novel tells of a young enslaved woman named Sethe who runs away from her enslavers and, at the point of recapture, kills her infant daughter in order to spare her a life of slavery. Eighteen years later, the daughter returns to haunt Sethe and other family members, a plot development that many readers and critics interpreted as a metaphor for America's haunting legacy of slavery. The novel was praised for its compelling storytelling and evocative prose, a mix of African American dialect and stream of consciousness

NOBLE PRIZE

- In 1992 Morrison released *Jazz*, a story of violence and passion set in New York City's Harlem during the 1920s; a research assistant on the book was Princeton student MacKenzie (Bezos) Scott. The following year she received the Nobel Prize for Literature. In her Nobel lecture, Morrison spoke of the power of language and its capability to bring meaning to the human experience:

LEGACY

- The central theme of Morrison's novels is the Black American experience; in an unjust society, her characters struggle to find themselves and their cultural identity. Her use of fantasy, her sinuous poetic style, and her rich interweaving of the mythic gave her stories great strength and texture. In 2010 Morrison was made an officer of the French Legion of Honor. Two years later she was awarded the U.S. Presidential Medal of Freedom. Toni Morrison: The Pieces I Am (2019) is a documentary about her life and career.

THANK YOU